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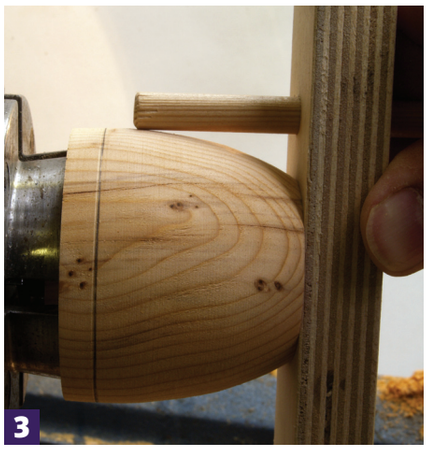
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The 'church window' box

1 Using the planned dimensions as a guide, turn a suitably sized piece spindle grain orientated of yew down to 65mm between centres, and form dovetails on each end. Mark out a section at about 45mm for the box bottom and take the remainder down to a diameter a little more than 45mm, then part off. This section will be used for the lid

2 Use a bowl gouge to reduce the outside of the blank to the approximate shape required, maintaining the small diameter at just over 45mm. The inside is rough hollowed using a spindle gouge with its flute at about 10 o'clock, pulling it from the centre out towards the edge

3 Yew is prone to small cracks and shakes but you can fill them with superglue. Use thin glue and give it time to penetrate the crack by capillary action. Allow time for the glue to set

4 Use a small scraper to complete the shaping and refine the inside surface. The scraper has the burr honed away and is used horizontally with the cutting edge at centre height or very slightly below. Take light cuts from the centre outwards and up the sides to the top. The curvature of the internal corners matches the shape of the scraper

5 Sand lightly with 240 and 400 grit papers before sealing with sanding sealer. Next, use a skew chisel to cut the shallow recess to accept the box lid

6 Mark the blank so that it can be replaced in the same position, remove it from the chuck and replace it with the lid section. Carefully turn down a short spigot to be a tight fit in the box. This requires a lot of 'trial and error'. Be patient!

7 Fit the box onto the lid. If the fit is good, the box will stay in place when the lathe is switched on but if in doubt, bring up the tailstock centre for extra support. With a small bowl gouge shape the lid to match the curvature of the box. Continue until the curve flows smoothly across the joint between the pieces. Once the external shape of the lid has been established, remove the box bottom and hollow the inside of the lid using the spindle gouge and scraper as before. Sand and seal the interior of the lid, and remove it from the chuck

8 Replace the box body section in the chuck and refit the lid, matching the grain pattern from box to lid. No matter how good the fit, the joint between box and lid will always be visible, so make a feature of it by cutting a narrow groove on the joint line. Complete the shaping of the lid and the ball on top. If the lid slips or comes off put a piece of tissue across the box and then insert the lid. This will tighten the fit enough to allow the ball to be finished

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